



Charge of the young brigade: Carlo Ancelotti placed his faith in Rodrygo, Vinícius Jr. (below), and new signing Jude Bellingham (in pic, left), a gamble that paid off. AFP

No room for errors in knockouts

The Champions League saw its first penalty shootout since the 2015-16 final between Real Madrid and Atletico Madrid when Arsenal faced Porto in the round of 16. The Gunners reached the final eight for the first time in 14 years after beating the Portuguese giants 4-2 in the shootout. However, Mikel Arteta's men could not escape the ghosts of their previous round-of-16 thrashing at the hands of Bayern Munich in 2016-17, faltering against the Bavarians in the quarterfinals this season.

Title holder Manchester City and competition royalty Real Madrid played an enthralling quarterfinal

first leg, which ended 3-3 at the Santiago Bernabéu Stadium in Madrid. At the Etihad Stadium, where it was eliminated the previous year, Ancelotti's side was better prepared and forced Pep Guardiola's men into their first-ever penalty shootout in the competition.

Ukrainian Andriy Lunin's heroics in the shootout ended City's quest for a second successive crown.

Barcelona squandered its

advantage from the first leg of its quarterfinal against PSG as former Barca winger Ousmane Dembele and marquee player Kylian Mbappe inspired the Parisians to stage a comeback in the reverse fixture. As a result, Luis Enrique became the first ex-Barcelona manager to eliminate the 'Culers' from a Champions League knockout stage.

Dortmund came back from a goal down in the first leg against Atletico Madrid to win the tie, which kept flipping until Marcel Sabitzer's magical three-minute spell in the second leg sent 'The Black and Yellow' into the final four.

Veteran Mats Hummels stood out in a team lacking big names, inspiring Dortmund to continue its dream run after beating PSG both home and away in the semifinal, ending Mbappe's seven-year tenure in the French capital without a taste of the UCL trophy.

In the other semifinal, after drawing the first leg 2-2 in Germany, Real Madrid found an unlikely



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